



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-136
FIRST IN COUNCIL
July 23, 2026

COUNCILLOR SIMMONS
COUNCILLOR FLAHERTY

- WHEREAS: The City of Cambridge utilized ShotSpotter gunfire-detection technology beginning in 2014 as one component of the City's response to incidents of suspected gunfire, particularly in circumstances in which no resident or witness called 911 to report that shots had been fired; and
- WHEREAS: On May 18, 2026, the Cambridge City Council voted to discontinue the City's use of ShotSpotter gunfire-detection technology following concerns raised about its effectiveness, privacy implications, and impact upon the community; and
- WHEREAS: The tragic fatal shooting that occurred in Cambridge during the early morning hours of July 4, 2026 has renewed concern regarding the City's ability to identify and respond promptly to incidents of gunfire that are not reported through a 911 call; and
- WHEREAS: In the days following this tragedy, residents have expressed significant concern regarding the discontinuation of ShotSpotter and whether the voices of those living in neighborhoods most affected by gun violence were sufficiently heard and considered before the technology was removed; and
- WHEREAS: The City Council must take seriously both the concerns raised regarding ShotSpotter and the concerns of residents who believe the technology may have provided an added layer of protection, particularly in circumstances in which gunfire might otherwise go unreported; and
- WHEREAS: No single technology can prevent gun violence or substitute for sustained investments in violence prevention, youth engagement, community outreach, trauma-informed services, effective policing, and neighborhood safety, but an existing public safety measure should not be removed without a clear understanding of whether residents wish to retain it and what additional or alternative protections will take its place; now therefore be it
- WHEREAS: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to take all necessary steps to temporarily restore and reactivate ShotSpotter within the areas of Cambridge previously covered by the system; and be it further
- ORDERED: That ShotSpotter remain in operation until the City has completed a robust and inclusive public process regarding its continued use, with particular attention given to the views of residents from neighborhoods most affected by gun violence, and until the City has developed and begun implementing additional or alternative measures to ensure that those neighborhoods are not left with fewer layers of public safety

protection; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to develop and present to the City Council a comprehensive neighborhood safety and gun violence prevention plan identifying the measures the City will employ to detect and respond to unreported gunfire, prevent violence, support affected residents and families, and provide additional protections within communities facing the greatest risk of gun violence; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to report back to the City Council within ninety days with the results of the public process, the proposed neighborhood safety and gun violence prevention plan, and recommendations regarding the continued use, modification, or replacement of ShotSpotter.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

A handwritten signature in dark ink, appearing to read "Paula M. Crane". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Paula" being more prominent.

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

That the City Manager is requested to take all necessary steps to temporarily restore and reactivate ShotSpotter within the areas of Cambridge previously covered by the system.